Shared game reviews — functional spec

Tracks #59 — Shared game reviews.

Overview

Reviewing a game today is a solo activity. The Review game button opens the game in the reviewer's own browser, where they step through it, try variations, and annotate positions. Nothing is saved, and nobody else can see any of it. Reviewing a game together means a screen share and a chat on some other service, and when the call ends the review is gone. With a small group of regular players, that is now the thing most in the way of talking about games.

This feature gives a finished game a review that other people can come to. A registrant opens a review of a finished game; it lives at a permanent address of its own. The reviewer drives: every move, variation, and annotation they make is saved and shown live to everyone watching. The review has its own chat, and every message remembers the board position it was posted at, so the conversation and the board stay connected, during the session and for anyone reading it afterwards.

The game review redesign (`doc/closed/2026-03-27-game-review-func-spec.md`) deferred three things this feature picks up: saving a review, comments attached to positions, and collaborative review. It is one feature, not an epic: the design is settled here in full, and the tech spec carves the build into stages.

The guiding principle for this first pass is the simplest design that makes a live review work and leaves a useful record behind. Many refinements are deliberately out of scope; see that section.

Note: the companion card #60 — Show move numbers is separate. Talking about a position is easier with a move number in reach, but this feature does not depend on it.

Domain language

All new terms belong to the review & canvas bounded context unless noted.

- **Review** — a saved, shared game review of one finished game, with its own address, its own game tree, and its own chat. A registrant has at most one review of a given game. "Game review" continues to mean the activity.

  Also considered: "study" (the Lichess term, rejected once already as borrowed), "review room" (over-specific; the review outlives any one session), "shared review" (the sharing is a property of every review, so the adjective carries nothing).

- **Reviewer** — the registrant who opened a review. The reviewer alone changes the review: the tree, the title, the current position. There is exactly one reviewer per review, for the review's whole life.

  Also considered: "host" and "editor". "Reviewer" is what people already say, and it reads naturally beside "spectator".

- **Spectator** (review & canvas) — anyone on a review page other than its reviewer: registrant, guest, or viewer. The identity context's *viewer* (a person who is not signed in) keeps its meaning; a viewer on a review page is one kind of spectator. This is the same word the play context uses for someone watching a game they are not playing, with the same sense, and it becomes a cross-context traveler.

- **Following** — the spectator state in which the board mirrors the reviewer's position. A spectator arrives following.

- **Browsing** — the spectator state in which the board shows a position the spectator chose. Any navigation of their own puts a spectator here.

- **Follow** — the control that returns a browsing spectator to following. It is lit while following.

- **Review chat** — the review's chat channel. *Chat channel*, *mention*, and *auto-hide* travel from the lobby chat with their meanings unchanged.

- **Message view** — the board as a chat message's author saw it when they sent the message: the position, plus the overlay that was on, if any. Restoring a message view puts both back.

  Also considered: "message position". It named only half of what is restored once overlays travel with it.

- **Review page** — the page at a review's address.

Opening a review

The Review game button

The Review game button on the game page is the one way to a review. While the game is in play it is disabled, with the tooltip "Reviews open when the game ends". Once the game is over it opens the Reviews dialog, for everyone. Any game that is over counts, however it ended: by counting, resignation, timeout, forfeit, or a moderation outcome.

Once the game is over, the game status bar's actions area also shows a Review game button, beside the rematch controls. It is the same button with the same behavior, placed where the eye goes when a game ends.

Motivation for disabling the button during play: the button has one meaning, a review of a finished game. The local scratch review of a game in progress that the button used to open had one habitual user, who can reach the same thing by saving the SGF and loading it in the board canvas.

The Reviews dialog

The dialog lists the game's reviews and offers the one action the person looking can take:

- the game's existing reviews, newest first, each a link named for its reviewer, or "No reviews yet"
- for a registrant, one action: "Open your review" if they have one of this game, "Start your review" if not
- for a guest or a viewer, the sign-in nudge in place of that action
- for a suspended registrant, no action: they may look but not participate, so the dialog lists the reviews and offers nothing to start

Starting a review opens the new review page directly. A registrant has at most one review of a game, so "Start your review" never appears beside a review they already have.

Motivation: reviews on OGS are easy to create by accident and hard to delete, which litters a game with empty reviews. One review per registrant per game removes the accident, the delete action below removes the litter, and seeing the existing reviews before starting one steers people into the review that is already going rather than a parallel one. That last point is what earns the dialog its extra click.

The nudge

The nudge for a guest or a viewer follows the tournament signup nudge: "Sign in or register to create a review", with sign-in and register links. It adds one line saying they can still download the game's SGF. It does not spell out what to do with the file.

The signup page's list of what an account gives you gains the entry "Create game reviews".

What a new review holds

- The tree's trunk is the game record, fixed, as in game review today. Variations branch from it.
- The title is the game's title. The reviewer can change it in place, as in game review today, and the change is saved.
- The current position is the final position of the game.

The announcement

When a review is opened, everyone on that game's page sees an ephemeral in the game status bar: "sully opened a review", with "review" linked to the review page. It follows the status bar's usual ephemeral behavior.

Motivation: the usual moment to open a review is right after the game ends, when both players and any spectators are still on the game page. The notice reaches exactly the people who want it, with no other discovery needed.

Finding a review

- A review has a permanent address. The reviewer pastes it into lobby chat to gather a room; chat already renders addresses as links.
- The Reviews dialog on the game page lists the game's reviews, and updates live as reviews are opened and deleted.
- Reviews are public. Anyone who can see the game can watch any of its reviews, viewers included, and read the chat.

Also considered: a reviews clause in the finished game's status bar baseline, "Reviews by sully and momo". Rejected: the baseline's job after a game is the result, the bar is one line, and the rematch suffix already shows what happens when something else needs the room, the result gets shortened.

The review page

Layout

The review page is the game review view with a chat panel beside the board, in the place the game page keeps its chat. The board stays the focal point. The chat panel collapses and expands as the game page's does, with the state remembered per device.

- **Landscape, chat open.** The game page's arrangement: status bar, board, and controls stacked in the left column, the chat in the right column. The controls take their compact form under the board, the form the canvas already uses in portrait, so the reviewer's full control set is known to fit there.
- **Landscape, chat collapsed.** The canvas layout as it is today, controls expanded beside the board, with the collapsed chat bar at the edge as on the game page.
- **Portrait.** The canvas's stack of title, board, and controls, with the chat docked as a collapsed bar at the bottom, as the lobby chat does.

Motivation: the canvas's expanded controls and the chat both want the right side of a landscape screen. With both on screen, the controls give way, since they already have a compact form and the chat does not.

The page heading is the review's title, with "Review by sully" beneath it.

Status bar

The review view's status bar keeps its current job, move and variation context, counting score, and score estimate, and adds a presence clause saying who is on the page. It names the reviewer and counts the spectators, and leaves out the person reading it when that person is the reviewer:

Who is reading	Reviewer on the page	Clause
a spectator	yes	"sully and 3 spectators are present."
a spectator	no	"3 spectators are present."
the reviewer	always	"3 spectators are present."

A spectator's count includes themselves, as the lobby's count does, so a spectator never reads a count of zero. The count follows the lobby's rules: a signed-in person in several tabs counts once, and viewers are

deduplicated best-effort per browser. The reviewer reads "No spectators are present." when alone. Singular forms read naturally: "sully and 1 spectator are present", "1 spectator is present". The clause updates live.

Motivation: a spectator arriving at a still board cannot otherwise tell whether anything is about to happen, and the reviewer wants to know whether anyone is there before talking to the room. One clause answers both.

The reviewer's controls

The reviewer gets the game review controls as they are today, plus a Delete review action. Everything the reviewer does to the review is saved as it happens and shown to following spectators as it happens:

- playing moves and passes, which create variations
- annotations
- entering and leaving counting mode, and territory toggles within it
- deleting a branch
- changing the title
- navigating, which moves the current position
- turning the score estimate or the heat map on and off, which following spectators see as the reviewer sees it

Overlays

The reviewer's board overlays are part of the review, not of the reviewer's browser.

- **Score estimate.** With the estimate on, each position the reviewer visits has its estimate computed once and recorded in the review at that position. Everyone who looks there afterwards sees the recorded estimate, the reviewer included: following spectators at the time, the reviewer on a later visit, and anyone restoring a message view.
- **Heat map.** Showing a heat map in a review pins its position analysis, so it survives the retention reaper and a message view pointing at it finds it later. A reader later sees the finished analysis, not the partial one the reviewer saw mid-search. A heat map whose analysis has been removed by hand is simply not drawn.

Motivation for recording the estimate: a re-run is close, not the same. When the reviewer has just said "White is ahead by 3", a latecomer's recompute saying 2.5 is a different picture. One recorded estimate per position is also one computation instead of one per spectator per look.

Note: heat maps are summoned only by admins, and that stays so. Mirroring means anyone following an admin's review sees them, so the gate's meaning narrows from "only an admin sees a heat map" to "only an admin can summon one". For a teaching review that is the point, and it bounds how many analyses reviews pin.

The reviewer is the only writer. If the reviewer has the review open in two places, the review follows whichever acted last.

The spectator's controls

A spectator's board is read-only. Their controls are:

- the navigator, as in game review today, including variation up and down and back to trunk, operating on the spectator's own position
- the Follow button
- the display toggles: coordinates and sound. Double tap exists for placing stones, so a read-only board has no use for it.

There are no click modes, no delete branch, and no title editing. A spectator cannot turn on an estimate or a heat map of their own; they see the reviewer's, while following or through a message view.

Following and browsing

- A spectator arrives following: their board shows the reviewer's position and overlay, and moves with them.
- Any navigation of their own, by navigator button, arrow key, or a chat message's view, puts them in browsing, and their board stays where they put it. The reviewer's overlay goes with following; an overlay restored from a message view stays until the spectator's next navigation.
- Pressing Follow returns them to following, position and overlay. The button is lit while following and plain while browsing, so it also tells a spectator which state they are in. It has a keyboard shortcut.
- Changes the reviewer makes to the tree while a spectator is browsing still arrive; the spectator's position does not move. If the reviewer deletes the branch the spectator is on, the spectator lands on the branch point.

The arrow keys keep their game review bindings for spectators: left and right step moves, up and down switch variations.

Following spectators hear the stone sounds for the reviewer's moves, as a spectator of a game hears the players'.

When the reviewer is away

A review is a page, not a session. When the reviewer is not on the page, the review shows the position they left it at. Following spectators see that position; browsing works as always; chat works as always. When the reviewer returns, following spectators move with them again.

Review chat

Posting

The review chat follows the lobby chat's rules exactly. In brief:

- Registrants and guests post directly. A viewer who sends a message passes the humanity check, becomes a guest, and the message posts as that guest.
- Suspended users read but cannot post.
- A message is plain text, trimmed, at most 300 characters, sent with Enter. Addresses render as links.
- Mentions by `@username` work as in the lobby, with autocomplete and highlighting.
- The chat opens on the most recent 50 messages and pages back. Messages are grouped under date separators and persist indefinitely.
- The chat sounds are the lobby chat's.

Message view

Every message carries its message view: the board as its author saw it when they sent the message, the position plus whichever overlay was on, if any. For a following spectator and for the reviewer that is the reviewer's position and overlay; for a browsing spectator it is their own.

- Each message shows a small view marker. Clicking the marker restores the message view: a spectator goes browsing there, overlay included, and the reviewer moves the whole room there. Links and mentions inside the message text keep their own targets.
- Messages whose position is the position currently on the reader's board are highlighted, so when the room is at a position, the messages about that position stand out.
- A message whose position has been deleted from the tree takes you to the nearest surviving position: after a branch deletion, the branch point. No overlay is restored in that case.

Motivation: the message view is the one piece that pays off in every mode. Live, it lets the reviewer pull the room back to the point someone raised. Afterwards, it lets a reader walk the conversation through the tree and see what the reviewer was pointing at, including the estimate or heat map they were talking about.

Note: the exact click target, the marker alone or the whole message, is a decision for the screen, not the document. On touch devices a tap on the message already reveals its actions.

Moderation

Moderation is the lobby chat's, unchanged: per-message reporting with the chat reasons, aggregation of reports onto one request, auto-hide at the threshold, the same resolution outcomes, and the moderator's direct delete and delete-all-by-author within the review's channel. The moderator page shows a reported review message in its surrounding context as it does a lobby message.

Deleting a review

- The reviewer deletes their review from the review page, behind a confirmation dialog, at any time.
- A moderator can delete any review from its page, behind the same confirmation. This is the one moderation tool for the review itself, as distinct from its chat: a title or an annotation that has no business on a public page goes with the review.
- The review page and its address stop working. A spectator on the page at that moment sees a notice that the review was deleted, with a link back to the game, and a later visit to the address shows the same notice.
- The game page's Reviews dialog no longer lists it.
- The review's chat messages become deleted messages, as a moderator's deletion leaves them: gone for everyone, kept for moderators. An open moderation request about one of them keeps its evidence and is resolved as usual.

Motivation: deleting a review must not be a way to erase the evidence for a report against its author, and the chat already has a deletion state that keeps evidence while removing the message from view.

Motivation for moderator deletion: a strike against the reviewer freezes the review but leaves its title and annotations on a public page. Deletion is the minimal tool that covers it; see out of scope for the fuller version.

Suspension and game moderation

- A suspended reviewer may look but not participate: they cannot change the tree or post, and following spectators see the position where the review stands. The reviewer can still delete the review.
- A moderation outcome on the game itself, an annulled or overturned result, does not affect the game's reviews.

Out of scope

- **Move numbers**, on the main line or anywhere, and navigating to a move by number — *later*: wanted, and tracked on its own as #60, because it serves the game page and the canvas as much as reviews.
- **Spectators stepping through messages** with navigator buttons, the chat history as a timeline — *later*: a coherent model on its own, but clicking a message already navigates, and one metaphor for spectators is enough for a first pass.
- **A named roster of who is watching** — *later*: the count answers the reviewer's question; a roster has its own privacy questions, as the lobby's does.
- **Spectators running their own score estimate or heat map** — *later*: spectators see the reviewer's; their own would need analysis controls in the spectator panel and a story for how they relate to the reviewer's.
- **Reviews of games in progress**, with the trunk following the live game — *never*: a public running commentary on a game still being played is bad manners toward the players, whatever the machinery would cost. A review is of a finished game.
- **An admin-only scratch review of a game in progress** — *maybe later*: the saved-SGF path covers it; add the button behavior back if the two extra clicks grate.

- **Reviews from a blank board or an SGF upload** — *later*: each adds setup UI; a finished game is the one starting point for now.
- **Private or invite-only reviews** — *maybe later*: a membership model and access checks on every surface, for a group that fits in one lobby chat today.
- **Handing the reviewer role to someone else**, or several reviewers — *later*: a single writer for the whole life of the review keeps the first pass simple.
- **A list or notice of live reviews in the lobby** — *later*: pasting the address into lobby chat does this today; revisit once there are enough reviews to list.
- **A reviews list in the game info panel** — *maybe later*: the Reviews dialog is the list; a second copy in the info panel is cheap but adds nothing until someone misses it.
- **Per-position comment fields** on tree nodes, the SGF notion of a comment — *maybe later*: the message view is the comment mechanism here; a second one would duplicate it.
- **Editing or deleting one's own messages** — *maybe later*: as in the lobby chat.
- **Fuller moderation of the review itself**: reporting a review, a moderation request with the review as its subject, resolution outcomes short of deletion — *later*: moderator deletion is the minimal tool for a title or an annotation that has no business on a public page, and is enough while reviews are few. Beef it up when the community is big enough to need the queue.

Signoff

Roles	Name	LGTU?	Date
Func Spec Author, Architect	Sully	LGTM	2026-10-20
Func Spec Author, Tech Spec Author	Cosmo	LGTM	2026-10-20